

market, but quite frankly, I was lying. I really wanted one good tip on a company that was about to be taken over, or some other stock that was bound to go up fast.

This was just before Mr. Boesky was caught and plead guilty to insider trading. Prior to his legal troubles, Mr. Boesky's information was thought to be just as legitimate as everybody else's information—only more valuable.

"You should try to see him in the morning," my brother-in-law said. "I heard he drives in from Westchester in a Winnebago with a satellite dish on the top and already has bought millions worth of stocks before he crosses the river and hits Manhattan." My brother-in-law put in a call to Mr. Boesky, but Mr. Boesky didn't return it. That, he said, was unusual.

I went to Mr. Boesky's office building on Fifth Avenue to try to collar him in person, but there were guards at the elevators. Then I searched for a basement to see if I could look through Mr. Boesky's trash. I hoped to find some scrap of paper that would indicate what he was doing, but I couldn't find a basement, or anything resembling a trash bin around the entire block. In this expensive part of New York, trash seemed to disappear on its own.

Having no luck at seeing Mr. Boesky or even examining his droppings, I did what seemed like the next best thing. I approached some of his competitors. These were other so-called risk arbitrageurs from a reputable firm that asked to have their name kept out of this. I made up a pseudonym, Z. B. Troutman.

To get into the room at Z. B. Troutman where the risk arbs who competed with Mr. Boesky did their trading wasn't easy. First I had to contact a friend of another friend, a respected Wall Street analyst who'd become Z. B. Troutman's *éminence grise*. Unfortunately, he only liked to talk about what was wrong with the markets. I wanted a profitable hint, while he wanted to bemoan the decline of the morality on Wall Street. He reminisced about the old days when people held on to stocks, when they took their positions based on a faith in industry, when they "invested" instead of "speculated." It was a dark picture he painted, I'll tell you that. Some of the notes I took include phrases like "everything's up for sale," "no honor among thieves," "the word is, 'quick profit,' "